



IN THE BIG LEAGUE

More foreign tourists prefer Kochi to other Indian ports

YEAR	NUMBER OF PASSENGERS
2003-04	8,862
2004-05	9,517
2005-06	11,563
2006-07	16,018
2007-08	15,441

be used for high-profile business meetings, networking conclaves and client-entertaining programmes. The six-month long race is constantly monitored by onboard cameras and the images are beamed worldwide. "It's a golden opportunity to showcase India and Kerala as global destinations," says V. Venu, state tourism secretary. The major sponsors last year included Ericsson, Puma, Nike and ABN-Amro.

A key reason which helped Kochi clinch the deal is its recent emergence as a favoured destination for luxury cruise vessels. Today Kochi attracts the largest number of cruisers, thanks to the state's reputation as a tourism hotspot. This year, a record 43 cruisers have arrived, which include maiden voyages of some of the world's most famous and largest vessels like Queen Victoria and Queen Mary II.

"This is my second visit to Kochi which is my favourite port in India, thanks to its old world village charm combined with the modern facilities," says Joseph Kohen from California who was among the passengers in the Crystal Serenity, the American cruiser

that arrived at Kochi on April 7. A world-class marina is soon to come up in Kochi besides an exclusive cruise terminal at the port. An American firm has prepared the feasibility report for the Rs 230-crore cruise terminal which will house a five-star hotel, shopping malls, food courts, a Kerala village etc. "Cruise vessels do not bring money to the port like cargo ships. Hence we are trying to build up other attractions like hotels, malls etc," says Vipin R. Menoth, additional traffic manager, CPT. "We find it our corporate social responsibility to promote Kerala as a tourism destination." Construction has already begun on a Rs 2,500-crore new international transshipment terminal for CPT which is among the 12 major ports of the country. Modernisation programmes to make Kochi an e-port are also afoot now.

Location advantage was another reason for Kochi's selection. The port is strategically located in the busy international sea route with just 11 nautical miles from the Gulf-Singapore-Far East route and 70 nautical miles off Suez-Singapore-Far East while

Mumbai is 430 nautical miles off. Kochi is the maritime gateway for peninsular India.

But, the yachting extravaganza has posed some challenges for the hosts. "The biggest constraint is the need for about 5,000 premium hotel rooms which are not available in Kochi. Hence we are building houseboat villages on the waters which would accommodate the visitors," says Venu.

Ramachandran, who had met the race organisers at Alicante, Spain, says he was amazed by the preparations underway in Qingdao. They have taken it as part of their preparations for the Beijing Olympics. An old shipyard in Qingdao, which has been converted into a modern marina to host the Olympic sailing regatta, is the venue for the Volvo race. "Though we have no resources on that scale, Kochi would be an unforgettable experience for the Volvo race," says Kodiyeeri Balakrishnan, state tourism minister.

Even if India fails to put up a show as big as its neighbour, Kerala must ensure that it lives up to its worldwide fame as God's own country. ■

SAIL IN STYLE

■ The Volvo Ocean Race was initially established as Whitbread round in world race in 1973

■ The race commences its round-the-world marathon sailing this year from Alicante, Spain, on October 4, 2008 and ends at St Petersburg, Russia, on June 9, 2009

■ The race will cover 30,000 nautical miles and will pass through 11 ports across the world

■ Its route will include India and China for the first time

■ Kochi has been picked as the only stopover in South Asia

■ The yachts will anchor in Kochi for 10 days from December 3 to 13

■ The touchdown ports for the race will be: Alicante, Cape Town (South Africa), Kochi, Singapore, Qingdao (China), Rio de Janeiro (Brazil), Boston (US), Galway (Ireland), Goteborg and Stockholm (Sweden), St Petersburg